





WINNING CAST Clockwise from left, Arjun Rampal as ISI officer Major Iqbal, Rakesh Bedi as Pakistani politician Jameel Jamali, R. Madhavan as Ajay Sanyal



"*DHURANDHAR* DOES NOT MISS A BEAT IN SEAMLESSLY INTEGRATING CONTEMPORARY POP CULTURE AND POLITICS... IT REFERENCES PHRASES LIKE "*GHAR MAIN GHUSENGE AUR MARENGE*" TO CEMENT THE STORY'S AUTHENTICITY AND RELATABILITY"

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to be polite. The writing cuts with intent, the staging breathes menace, and the silences are as weaponised as the thunderous sound effects." Even director Anurag Kashyap, in his Letterboxd review of Part 1, said that, barring some dialogues, the filmmaking is top-notch and he admires Dhar's "stubbornness". "Agree or disagree with [the politics]," he writes, "the man is honest."

Those who worked on the film saw the wave coming even if they couldn't predict its sheer scale. National Award-winning sound designer Bishwadeep Chatterjee knows Dhar from when he assisted Vidhu Vinod Chopra on *Eklavya* (2007) and the "quiet determination" he showed. "He called me over to his house and made this beautiful AI presentation on how the characters [in *Dhurandhar*] would look, unravelling the entire gist of the film," says Chatterjee, who also worked on *Uri*. "Amidst the whole chaos of 'release date is coming!', he's Buddha. He's like, '*Ho jaayega*'."

BOLLYWOOD'S NEW OBSESSION

Even those who collaborated with Dhar for the first time came away impressed with the 43-year-old filmmaker. "Dhar's vision was huge," says Anand Bhanushali, MD & co-founder, philmCGI, one of the visual effects companies that worked on the duology. "I remember seeing the rushes in mid-2025 and had this gut feeling that the film is something different, it's special." Dhar and his team scouted nine countries before settling on Thailand for the location to set up Karachi's Lyari.

"Creating Karachi in India would have been a logistical nightmare. Just think about putting up Pakistani flags in Indian markets with about 800 people," Kulthep Narula, COO, Benetone Films, who worked on the film, sais at an event recently. About 40 people from India and 100 from Thailand constructed the sets on a six-acre location in six weeks.

For Deshpande, *Dhurandhar* is amplification of what cinema needs to do: tell stories that have a purpose. For the makers, *Dhurandhar*'s global success is a matter of pride for India. "When we see what's happening in the world and where India is, we always focus on the problems here. But don't we have a responsibility to inspire our youth and make them bet on India, so the best brains don't leave it?" she said. "It's time to claim our narrative, not about religion and politics, but about India." The reason, then, for *Dhurandhar* and its sequel becoming such a blockbuster success is not just the heady mix of patriotism, gripping brutality, vengeance and sacrifice that its makers tapped into but something deeper: the story of a nation repeatedly tested, bloodied, but never broken—an India that absorbs every blow, rises again and ultimately prevails. ■